
INTERNATIONAL AS ENGLISH LITERATURE

Unit 1 Aspects of dramatic tragedy

Tuesday 6 January 2026

07:00 UK Time

Time allowed: 2 hours

Materials

For this paper you must have:

- an OxfordAQA 12-page Answer Book.

Instructions

- Use black ink or black ball-point pen.
- Write the information required on the front of your answer book.
- Do all rough work in your answer book. Cross through any work you do not want to be marked.
- You must answer **one** question from Section A and **one** question from Section B.
- Remember to include, in both your answers, relevant comments on the authors' dramatic methods in the set texts you are studying.

Information

- The maximum mark for this paper is 50.
- The marks for questions are shown in brackets.
- You will be marked on your ability to:
 - use good English
 - organise information clearly
 - analyse carefully the writers' methods
 - use specialist vocabulary where appropriate.

Section A: Elizabethan and Jacobean tragedy

Answer **one** question from this section.

Either

0	1
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William Shakespeare: *Othello*

Explore the significance of the aspects of dramatic tragedy in the following passage in relation to the play as a whole.

You should consider the following in your answer:

- the presentation of Othello and Iago
- Shakespeare's use of dialogue
- the dramatic setting and action
- other relevant aspects of dramatic tragedy.

[25 marks]

Act 4 Scene 1**IAGO**

How now, Cassio!

CASSIO

What's the matter?

IAGO

My lord is fallen into an epilepsy – This is his second fit; he had one yesterday.

CASSIO

Rub him about the temples.

IAGO

No, forbear:

The lethargy must have his quiet course;
If not, he foams at mouth, and by and by
Breaks out to savage madness. Look, he stirs.
Do you withdraw yourself a little while:
He will recover straight; when he is gone,
I would on great occasion speak with you.

[Exit CASSIO]

How is it, general? Have you not hurt your head?

OTHELLO

Dost thou mock me?

IAGO

I mock you not, by heaven!
Would you would bear your fortune like a man.

OTHELLO

A horned man's a monster and a beast.

IAGO

There's many a beast then in a populous city,
And many a civil monster.

OTHELLO

Did he confess it?

IAGO

Good sir, be a man:
Think every bearded fellow that's but yoked
May draw with you. There's millions now alive
That nightly lie in those unproper beds,
Which they dare swear peculiar. Your case is better.
O, 'tis the spite of hell, the fiend's arch-mock,
To lip a wanton in a secure couch,
And to suppose her chaste. No, let me know;
And knowing what I am, I know what she shall be.

OTHELLO

O, thou art wise; 'tis certain.

IAGO

Stand you awhile apart;
Confine yourself but in a patient list:
Whilst you were here o'erwhelmed with your grief--
A passion most unsuiting such a man--
Cassio came hither. I shifted him away,
And laid good 'scuse upon your ecstasy;
Bade him anon return and here speak with me --
The which he promised. Do but encave yourself,
And mark the fleers, the gibes, and notable scorns,
That dwell in every region of his face.
For I will make him tell the tale anew:
Where, how, how oft, how long ago, and when
He hath, and is again to cope your wife.
I say, but mark his gesture -- marry, patience!
Or I shall say you are all in all in spleen,
And nothing of a man.

OTHELLO

Dost thou hear, Iago?
I will be found most cunning in my patience,
But -- dost thou hear? -- most bloody.

This extract continues on the next page

IAGO

That's not amiss;

But yet keep time in all. Will you withdraw?

[OTHELLO retires]

Now will I question Cassio of Bianca,

A hussy that by selling her desires

Buys herself bread and clothes. It is a creature

That dotes on Cassio – as 'tis the strumpet's plague

To beguile many, and be beguiled by one.

He, when he hears of her, cannot refrain

From the excess of laughter. Here he comes.

[Enter CASSIO]

As he shall smile, Othello shall go mad;

And his unbookish jealousy must construe

Poor Cassio's smiles, gestures and light behaviours

Quite in the wrong. – How do you now, lieutenant?

There are no questions printed on this page

Turn over for the next question

or

0	2
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William Shakespeare: *King Lear*

Explore the significance of the aspects of dramatic tragedy in the following passage in relation to the play as a whole.

You should consider the following in your answer:

- the presentation of Goneril and Albany
- Shakespeare's use of dialogue
- the dramatic setting and action
- other relevant aspects of dramatic tragedy.

[25 marks]

Act 4 Scene 2

Enter Goneril and Edmund, the bastard.

GONERIL

Welcome, my lord. I marvel our mild husband
Not met us on the way.

[Enter OSWALD, the steward]

Now, where's your master?

OSWALD

Madam, within; but never man so changed.
I told him of the army that was landed;
He smiled at it. I told him you were coming;
His answer was "The worse." Of Gloucester's treachery
And of the loyal service of his son
When I informed him, then he called me sot
And told me I had turned the wrong side out.
What most he should most defy seems pleasant to him;
What like, offensive.

GONERIL

[to EDMUND]

Then shall you go no further.
It is the cowish terror of his spirit
That dares not undertake. He'll not feel wrongs
Which tie him to an answer. Our wishes on the way
May prove effects. Back, Edmund, to my brother.
Hasten his musters and conduct his powers.
I must change arms at home, and give the distaff
Into my husband's hands. This trusty servant
Shall pass between us. Ere long you are like to hear,
If you dare venture in your own behalf,
A mistress's command. Wear this. Spare speech.
Decline your head. This kiss, if it durst speak,
Would stretch thy spirits up into the air.
[She kisses him] Conceive, and fare thee well.

EDMUND

Yours in the ranks of death.

[He exits]

GONERIL

My most dear Gloucester. To thee a woman's services are due;

My foot usurps my body.

OSWALD

Madam, here comes my lord.

[He exits]

[Enter Albany]

GONERIL

I have been worth the whistling.

ALBANY

O Goneril, You are not worth the dust which the rude wind

Blows in your face. I fear your disposition.

That nature which contemns its origin

Cannot be bordered certain in itself.

She that herself will sliver and disbranch

From her material sap perforce must wither

And come to deadly use.

GONERIL

No more. The text is foolish.

ALBANY

Wisdom and goodness to the vile seem vile;

Filths savour but themselves. What have you done?

Tigers, not daughters, what have you performed?

A father, and a gracious aged man,

Whose reverence even the head-lugged bear would lick,

Most barbarous, most degenerate, have you madded.

Could my good-brother suffer you to do it –

A man, a prince by him so benefacted?

If that the heavens do not their visible spirits

Send quickly down to tame these vile offences,

It will come,

Humanity must perforce prey on itself,

Like monsters of the deep.

or

0	3
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William Shakespeare: *Hamlet*

Explore the significance of the aspects of dramatic tragedy in the following passage in relation to the play as a whole.

You should consider the following in your answer:

- the presentation of Horatio and Hamlet
- Shakespeare's use of dialogue
- the dramatic setting and action
- other relevant aspects of dramatic tragedy.

[25 marks]

Act 5 Scene 2

HAMLET *[Giving him a paper]*

Here's the commission; read it at more leisure.
But wilt thou hear me how I did proceed?

HORATIO

I beseech you.

HAMLET

Being thus benetted round with villains –
Ere I could make a prologue to my brains,
They had begun the play – I sat me down,
Devised a new commission, wrote it fair.
I once did hold it, as our statists do,
A baseness to write fair, and laboured much
How to forget that learning, but, sir, now
It did me yeoman's service. Wilt thou know
Th'effect of what I wrote?

HORATIO

Ay, good my lord.

HAMLET

An earnest conjuration from the King,
As England was his faithful tributary,
As love between them like the palm should flourish,
As peace should still her wheaten garland wear
And stand a comma 'tween their amities,
And many such-like 'as'es of great charge,
That, on the view and know of these contents,
Without debatement further more or less,
He should the bearers put to sudden death,
Not shriving-time allowed.

HORATIO

How was this sealed?

HAMLET

Why, even in that was heaven ordinant.
 I had my father's signet in my purse,
 Which was the model of that Danish seal;
 Folded the writ up in form of th'other,
 Subscribed it, gave't the impression, placed it safely,
 The changeling never known. Now the next day
 Was our sea-fight; and what to this was sequent
 Thou know'st already.

HORATIO

So Guildenstern and Rosencrantz go to't.

HAMLET

Why, man, they did make love to this employment;
 They are not near my conscience. Their defeat
 Does by their own insinuation grow.
 'Tis dangerous when the baser nature comes
 Between the pass and fell incensed points
 Of mighty opposites.

HORATIO

Why, what a king is this!

HAMLET

Does it not, think'st thee, stand me now upon –
 He that hath killed my king and whored my mother,
 Popped in between th'election and my hopes,
 Thrown out his angle for my proper life,
 And with such cozenage – is't not perfect conscience,
 To quit him with this arm? And is't not to be damned,
 To let this canker of our nature come
 In further evil?

HORATIO

It must be shortly known to him from England
 What is the issue of the business there.

HAMLET

It will be short: the interim is mine;
 And a man's life's no more than to say 'one'.
 But I am very sorry, good Horatio,
 That to Laertes I forgot myself;
 For by the image of my cause, I see
 The portraiture of his. I'll court his favours.
 But sure the bravery of his grief did put me
 Into a tow'ring passion.

or

0	4
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Christopher Marlowe: *Doctor Faustus*

Explore the significance of the aspects of dramatic tragedy in the following passage in relation to the play as a whole.

You should consider the following in your answer:

- the presentation of Faustus, Mephistopheles and the Pope
- Marlowe's use of dramatic language
- the dramatic setting
- other relevant aspects of dramatic tragedy.

[25 marks]

Act 3 Scene 2

A sennet while the banquet is brought in, and then enter FAUSTUS and MEPHISTOPHELES in their own shapes.

MEPHISTOPHELES

Now, Faustus, come prepare thyself for mirth;
The sleepy cardinals are hard at hand
To censure Bruno that is posted hence
And on a proud-paced steed, as swift as thought,
Flies o'er the Alps to fruitful Germany,
There to salute the woeful Emperor.

FAUSTUS

The pope will curse them for their sloth today,
That slept both Bruno and his crown away.
But now, that Faustus may delight his mind
And by their folly make some merriment,
Sweet Mephistopheles, so charm me here
That I may walk invisible to all
And do what e'er I please, unseen of any.

MEPHISTOPHELES

Faustus, thou shalt. Then kneel down presently,
[FAUSTUS kneels]
Whilst on thy head I lay my hand
And charm thee with this magic wand.
[Presenting a magic girdle]
First wear this girdle, then appear
Invisible to all are here.
The planets seven, the gloomy air,
Hell, and the Furies' forked hair,
Pluto's blue fire, and Hecate's tree,
With magic spells so compass thee
That no eye may thy body see.
[FAUSTUS rises]
So, Faustus, now for all their holiness,
Do what thou wilt, thou shalt not be discerned.

FAUSTUS

Thanks, Mephistopheles. Now, Friars, take heed
Lest Faustus make your shaven crowns to bleed.

MEPHISTOPHELES

Faustus, no more. See where the cardinals come.
[Enter POPE and all the lords. Enter the Cardinals with a book]

POPE

Welcome, lord cardinals. Come sit down.
Lord Raymond, take your seat.
[They sit]

Friars attend,
And see that all things be in readiness,
As best beseems this solemn festival.

FIRST CARDINAL

First, may it please your sacred Holiness,
To view the sentence of the reverend synod,
Concerning Bruno and the emperor.

POPE

What needs this question? Did I not tell you,
Tomorrow we would sit i'th'consistory,
And there determine of his punishment?
You brought us word even now, it was decreed,
That Bruno and the cursed emperor
Were by the holy council both condemned
For loathed Lollards, and base schismatics.
Then wherefore would you have me view that book?

FIRST CARDINAL

Your Grace mistakes. You gave us no such charge.

RAYMOND

Deny it not; we all are witnesses
That Bruno here was late delivered you,
With his rich triple crown to be reserved
And put into the Church's treasury.

BOTH CARDINALS

By holy Paul, we saw them not.

POPE

By Peter, you shall die
Unless you bring them forth immediately. –
Hale them to prison. Lade their limbs with gyves! –
False prelates, for this hateful treachery
Cursed be your souls to hellish misery.
[Exeunt Attendants with the two Cardinals]

or

0	5
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John Webster: *The Duchess of Malfi*

Explore the significance of the aspects of dramatic tragedy in the following passage in relation to the play as a whole.

You should consider the following in your answer:

- the presentation of Ferdinand and the Doctor
- Webster's use of dialogue
- the dramatic setting and action
- other relevant aspects of dramatic tragedy.

[25 marks]

Act 5 Scene 2

[Enter PESCARA and a DOCTOR]

PESCARA

Now, doctor, may I visit your patient?

DOCTOR

If't please your lordship; but he's instantly
To take the air here in the gallery
By my direction.

PESCARA

Pray thee, what's his disease?

DOCTOR

A very pestilent disease, my lord,
They call lycanthropia.

PESCARA

What's that?
I need a dictionary to't.

DOCTOR

I'll tell you:
In those that are possessed with't there o'erflows
Such melancholy humour, they imagine
Themselves to be transformed into wolves;
Steal forth to churchyards in the dead of night,
And dig dead bodies up; as two nights since
One met the Duke 'bout midnight in a lane
Behind Saint Mark's church, with the leg of a man
Upon his shoulder; and he howled fearfully;
Said he was a wolf, only the difference
Was a wolf's skin was hairy on the outside,
His on the inside; bade them take their swords,
Rip up his flesh, and try. Straight I was sent for,
And, having ministered to him, found his grace
Very well recovered.

PESCARA

I am glad on't.

DOCTOR

Yet not without some fear
Of a relapse. If he grow to his fit again,
I'll go a nearer way to work with him
Than ever Paracelsus dreamed of. If
They'll give me leave, I'll buffet his madness out of him.
Stand aside, he comes.

[Enter FERDINAND, MALATESTI and CARDINAL; BOSOLA apart]

FERDINAND

Leave me.

MALATESTI

Why doth your lordship love this solitariness?

FERDINAND

Eagles commonly fly alone: they are crows, daws,
and starlings that flock together. Look, what's that follows me?

MALATESTI

Nothing, my lord.

FERDINAND

Yes.

MALATESTI

'Tis your shadow.

FERDINAND

Stay it; let it not haunt me.

MALATESTI

Impossible, if you move, and the sun shine.

FERDINAND

I will throttle it.

[Throws himself upon his shadow.]

MALATESTI

O, my lord, you are angry with nothing.

FERDINAND

You are a fool. How is't possible I should catch
my shadow unless I fall upon 't? When I go to hell, I mean
to carry a bribe; for, look you, good gifts evermore make way
for the worst persons.

This extract continues on the next page

PESCARA

Rise, good my lord.

FERDINAND

I am studying the art of patience.

PESCARA

'Tis a noble virtue.

FERDINAND

To drive six snails before me, from this town to Moscow;
neither use goad nor whip to them, but let them take their own time
—the patient'st man I' th' world match me for an experiment—
and I'll crawl after like a sheep-biter.

CARDINAL

Force him up.

[They raise him.]

FERDINAND

Use me well, you were best. What I have done, I have
done; I'll confess nothing.

There are no questions printed on this page

Turn over for Section B

Section B: Later dramatic tragedies

Answer **one** question from this section.

Either

0 6

Arthur Miller: *Death of a Salesman*

'In *Death of a Salesman*, women are presented as either shadowy figures or tragic victims.'

To what extent do you agree with this view of the play?

[25 marks]

or

0 7

Tennessee Williams: *A Streetcar Named Desire*

Consider the view that the tragic ending of *A Streetcar Named Desire* presents a bitter and disillusioned view of life. There are no ideals worth fighting for; life is simply a struggle for survival.

To what extent do you agree with this view of the play?

[25 marks]

or

0 8

Henrik Ibsen: *Hedda Gabler*

'In *Hedda Gabler*, Hedda and Loevborg are presented as very different kinds of rebels, and their rebellion is tragic in very different ways.'

To what extent do you agree with this view of the two characters?

[25 marks]

or

0 9

Samuel Beckett: *Waiting for Godot*

'In the tragedy of *Waiting for Godot*, time is presented as an enemy.'

To what extent do you agree with this view of the play?

[25 marks]

or

1 0

Brian Friel: *Translations*

In *Translations*, to what extent is Yolland presented simply as a passive, tragic victim?

[25 marks]

END OF QUESTIONS

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